

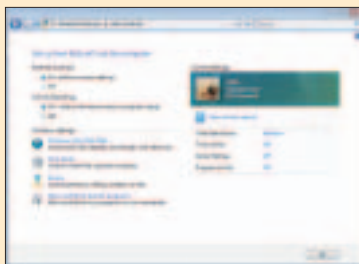
Unnatural disaster

Anyone wishing to prevent disaster from happening will naturally be concerned about security issues, and Windows Vista introduces the Security Center as the focal point for this. Security Center ensures there is a firewall in place to protect against the potential threat of malware, as well as ensuring that Automatic Updates are enabled so that Vista always has the latest fixes and patched installed. The Security Center will also warn you if there is no anti-virus software installed (Vista doesn't feature any built-in antivirus programs, as we'll see later on), while Windows Defender will help to protect against malware infection, malicious downloads and a variety of other internet-borne threats. Should any of these defence mechanisms be disabled, or if they are not installed, the Security Center will alert you to the fact and suggest steps that should be taken.

The security of Vista's new web browser — Internet Explorer 7 — also goes a long way to helping protect your computer. It can auto-

Take control of your PC

If other people use your computer, there is always the danger that they will change a system setting or perform a task that has unwanted side-effects. One way to help prevent this from happening is to use Vista's Parental Controls. This feature has been designed to place restrictions on children using a computer, but it can also be employed to restrict other users. Ensure that there are user accounts set up for everyone who is going to use the computer and that they have Standard rather than Administrator accounts as this will prevent undesired system-wide changes. Now open the Parental Controls Control Panel and work through each user account in turn. It is possible to restrict which programs can be run, block file downloads to help avoid malware infection and also block other websites. Parental Controls also make it possible to place restrictions on when the computer can be accessed and the types of games which can be played.



matically block access to websites that are known to be malicious (such as phishing sites), and prevent the appearance of pop-up windows, which can often include malicious links.

Another security concern for those with wireless home networks is encryption. Without encryption in place, it could be possible for others to gain access to your internet connection or, worse, your personal files and data.

Online threats

Even with all of these security measures in place, there is still potential for things to take a turn for the worse. To help avoid virus and malware infection, it is important to take care with all online activities. Care should be taken when downloading files from any website, or opening files attached to emails, for example. Do whatever research you can to reassure yourself that the website or email in question is genuine and use a virus scanner on the file before opening or executing it.



Windows Defender helps to protect against malware infections and other internet-borne threats

One of the most common problems with computers is that over time they slow down to a fraction of their performance speed when they were new. With regular maintenance, however, it is possible to virtually eliminate this slow down. In the Performance section of this Ultimate Guide, we'll be examining ways in which taking care of your computer and optimising settings will help keep your system running smoothly for as long as possible.

Like any sensitive piece of equipment, it's important to treat your Vista PC with care in order to prevent it from physically falling into disrepair. For instance, it is possible — although admittedly rare — for power surges to result in too much power being supplied to a system and its components, and this can result in hardware burning out and becoming broken beyond repair. The easiest way to avoid this problem is to invest in a surge protector. These are similar in appear-